# "THERE IS NO COMPROMISE IN OUR DEALS. IT'S A WIN-WIN"

**Union commerce minister PIYUSH GOYAL is the man of the moment, having signed two major back-to-back deals, one with the European Union and the other with the United States, within a week. Shortly after the joint statement on the Indo-US trade agreement, Group Editorial Director RAJ CHENGAPPA spoke with him to assess what these arrangements mean for India's economic growth and the potential benefits for the common man. Excerpts**

*Photograph by* **BANDEEP SINGH**

**Q. Do the recent trade agreements with the EU and US signal a fundamental shift in India's trade policy?**

They show that India has emerged out of the shadows. Today, it is a very self-confident country. It engages with the developed nations from a position of strength. Ultimately, free trade agreements are about the future. As India lays down the roadmap for a $30 trillion economy, the delta of opportunity from $4 trillion to $30 trillion is huge and unparalleled. All stars are aligned for this. We have a decisive leadership, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi leading from the front, willing to take risks, making bold reform decisions and transforming the mindset of the nation. We have the demographic dividend of young Indians under 30, which will last us for the next 30 years as we grow to a $30 trillion economy. I call it the power of 30-30-30. A population of 1.4 billion that is aspirational, desires all the good things in life and thus generates huge demand. In every respect, India stands at the threshold of a rapid growth story. And when we engage with partners like the US, EU, UK and others, we are preparing ourselves to engage with the best in terms of quality. We are preparing to leverage the strength of our youth's talent and skills. We are preparing our women to contribute much more to the formal economy. In effect, we are making inclusive growth and sustainability our mantra during this Amrit Kaal.

**Q. India, like many countries, had protective tariff walls in the past. What gives us the confidence now to open our doors while protecting our industry?**

The Congress and the UPA government under Prime Minister Manmohan Singh used to make a fundamental mistake while negotiating FTAs. They made them with less-developed or developing countries, who were largely our competitors. They lacked the courage of conviction to talk to the developed world other than Japan and Korea. And, sadly, both those terms are so badly negotiated that our exports to these two geographies have just not grown in the 15 years we have been there. Whereas every one of the trade deals Prime Minister Modi has inked in the past few years—from Mauritius, Australia, New Zealand, Oman, the UAE, the EFTA bloc to the EU and the UK—has been with economies that complement India's growth and are not in competition. We truly provide opportunities for their investments to work, leveraging their innovation and technologies, and providing jobs to Indians.

**Q. With the BJP a votary of the Swadeshi economic model, which critics see as protectionist, did your party or the Sangh Parivar resist these trade deals?**

I had no issue whatsoever. I say this with full confidence because we have not compromised any of our national interests in any of the deals. For example, our dairy sector has not been opened to imports in any of the FTAs. Countries like Switzerland, New Zealand, and the EU have never done an FTA without the dairy sector. We are the first because we were confident that we would be able to explain to them that we cannot compromise our small animal husbandry workers or farmers who may have just three or four livestock and can't compete with organised dairy in the developed world. We have an honest and plainspeaking approach in negotiations. Countries today trust Prime Minister Modi to give them a fair deal and recognise that India is a trusted partner that will only help their economies in the future. So, our idea is to capture the low-hanging fruit, not to make perfect the enemy of good, look for commonalities. I respect their sensitivities and they respect ours.